



MASQUERADE MURDER

THE STAG
CHARACTER GUIDE
(4 - 8 players)



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— HOST YOUR OWN MYSTERY —

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THE STAG

Masquerade Mystery

The year is 1755 and it's Carnival season in Venice, time for the masquerade ball.

A chance for rich and poor, old, and young to come together; everyone to be equal for a night. But when everyone is hiding their identity, it can be hard to know who you are talking to.

The question on everyone's lips is who is the figure in red? Seen conversing with several guests but no one admits to knowing them.

A glass smashes and the figure is found dead on the floor.

Who were they? And why did someone want them dead? It's your job to find out...



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CHARACTER GUIDE

CHARACTER DESCRIPTION:

Male, quite a wealthy man, owns a small estate on the Italian countryside. He's not aristocracy, but worked under The General and became good friends with him during the wars. He's polite and everybody likes him, but he's quiet and reclusive. He was quite handsome in his younger days. Even now in his 40s, he's still considered a handsome man, but no one seems to get his attention. He was in love many years ago with a woman, but she had no rank or fortune and his father forbid the marriage and sent her away. He tried to find her when he was no longer under his father's control, but was unable to locate her.

SPOILER ALERT!

DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST STARTS THE GAME!

THE STAG

ROUND 1

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLAYERS

INTROS

SAY HELLO!

Read this text word-for-word or paraphrase it in your own words as you introduce yourself to everyone. Don't add any information, just slang or casual language suitable for your character.

Hello, I'm Colonel R. Ecluse. I fought under The General in the wars but I've retired now. Tonight, I'm masquerading as The Stag; gentle unless provoked and perfectly capable of defending themselves if they need to but would rather avoid it if possible. They're independent and would much rather wander the forests alone than attend social gatherings but are obliged to do so every once in a while. That's rather like me. No, I never married. As a young man, my father tried to make me marry a rich woman, but I was already in love with another and no one would replace her in my heart and so I never did. I wish I knew where she was now.

YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH THE VICTIM

All the Players have a history with the victim. Try to keep the details of your relationship to yourself—but be aware that other people may already have some idea of it!

You hired Red Cloak to help you locate your lost love. You paid him a lot of money to find her, but he wasted it, didn't do the job and brought back no results. At least that's what he told you. However, later you found out that she was located within a week of searching and didn't tell you so he could get more money out of you.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE STAG

ROUND 1

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLAYERS

RUMOURS

CHOOSE YOUR VICTIM

Here are things you may have observed about other characters. In your group, agree on a character you want to talk about—someone who is at the party, but preferably not within earshot.

THE COUNTESS

The Countess cast Red Cloak out of society, he was involved in some sort of incident with her son a few years ago.

THE DRAGON

Red Cloak was calling on his sister a lot last year and was seen dancing at the winter ball but then suddenly he stopped. The sister was moved to their other house outside of Venice after that.

THE LION

Red Cloak was often seen at parties and theatres with The General's son. Even The General seemed to like him and promoted his work. That stopped suddenly after the summer ball.

THE STALLION

Used to hang out a lot with Red Cloak. They were friends and would often brag to each other about their conquests. This stopped after the summer ball when he danced a lot with his sister. Did something more happen there?

THE SHARK

Appealed to The Governor for Red Cloak to be arrested for immoral behaviour and severe misconduct but he never was.

THE BLACK SWAN

Was heard saying to Red Cloak this evening, "You'll not get another penny from me until you find someone suitable."

THE BLUEBIRD

She announced her engagement to Red Cloak at the summer ball. The engagement was broken off not long after.

THE MOUSE

Father was killed in a duel a few years ago. Word on the street was that it was against Red Cloak.

THE PHOENIX

Has a secret child – some rich gent knocked her up and refused to marry her, so she left Venice in disgrace.

THE DOG

Was overheard talking to Red Cloak earlier and saying, "How could you do this to her? Hasn't she suffered enough?"

THE CAT

Overheard saying to Red Cloak, "I should kill you for what you've done to my family. That money was all we had!"

THE HARE

Overheard talking to Red Cloak this evening saying, "I'll kill you myself if you even dare think of telling The General."

THE UNICORN

Was engaged to Red Cloak not long after the spring ball but called it off quite suddenly; it left her quite broken up, she nearly died of grief.

THE TURTLE

Very close with The Unicorn and threatened Red Cloak to a duel over her honour and heart ache.

THE SPARROW

Paid Red Cloak to accompany her to a few dances because she couldn't get a date any other way.

THE DOVE

Was in love with Red Cloak, they were supposed to get engaged, she was talking about it at the winter ball, but it never happened.

THE WOLF

Was heard saying to Red Cloak, "The plan has changed. I need my money back."

THE FOX

Was nothing but a farmer's son, but then suddenly, acquired a lot of wealth under very suspicious circumstances.

THE WEASEL

Was seen talking to Red Cloak, he handed him a bag of gold and hurried away.

SPREAD THE DIRT

Use your improvisational skills to share your rumour about that character with everyone in your group. Just as in real life, some people will already know your dirt—that doesn't mean you can't talk about it! The Host may ask you to move on to a different group, to share rumours with and about new people. Feel free to pass on or combine items you've heard from other Players. The Host may end the Round before you have finished, so get to the juicy stuff early!

BITE YOUR TONGUE!

If you hear someone spreading a rumour about you, pay attention but don't feel you need to answer. You'll have a chance to respond in the next Round.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE STAG

ROUND 2

MOTIVES

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud. Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE BLACK SWAN | THE CAT | THE WEASEL

"Scout Potential matches" sounds like a desperate cry for marriage. Financial security isn't an issue for some people here, but it is for you. Did you pay Red Cloak to help find a wealthy spouse?

ASK: THE COUNTESS

You have all the power in this society, and you cast Red Cloak out of it. Did you swear to kill him if he ever set foot in your house again?

ASK: THE STALLION | THE DRAGON

Red Cloak was seen at previous parties paying a lot of attention to your sister. Was there something going on there that you really didn't like?

ASK: THE LION

What happened to make you quite suddenly and publicly withdraw your support and funding for Red Cloak?

ASK: THE DOVE | THE BLUEBIRD | THE UNICORN

You were in love with Red Cloak once, weren't you? Did he break your heart too? He seems to have done that to a lot of people.

ASK: THE SPARROW

"Attend the Social" – it is fairly clear that that relates to you. Did you pay Red Cloak to accompany you to some dances?

ASK: THE HARE

What didn't you want Red Cloak to tell The General?

ASK: THE MOUSE | THE TURTLE

"Challenge to a duel." You are one of the few people here with a known history of duelling. Did you want Red Cloak to challenge someone?

ASK: THE PHOENIX

Rumour has it that you left Venice because you have an illegitimate child. Was Red Cloak the father?

ASK: THE WOLF

What plans changed? Was it you who asked Red Cloak to find "suitable lodgings?"

ASK: THE FOX

Red Cloak had a reputation for dirty dealing. Did he help you gain your wealth? A simple farmer's son would not normally achieve the fortune you have.

ASK: THE SHARK

You appealed for Red Cloak's arrest many times. Why?

ASK: THE DOG

Who were you referring to when you spoke to Red Cloak earlier? Who's suffered enough?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

When another Player asks you, read the appropriate answer.

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

I hired him to find someone. An old flame of mine, my family never approved the match and sent her away. After my father's passing, I wanted to find her. Red Cloak was supposed to do that. He found her, right here in Venice and didn't tell me, he just kept taking my money while he "searched" for her. Tonight, I was going to confront him about it, but I never got the chance because someone killed him. I just hope she knows that I was searching for her.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

I hired him to find someone. An old flame of mine, my family never approved the match and sent her away. After my father's passing, I wanted to find her. Red Cloak was supposed to do that. He found her, right here in Venice and didn't tell me, he just kept taking my money while he "searched" for her. Tonight, I was going to confront him about it.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE STAG

ROUND 3

METHOD

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud. Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE COUNTESS | THE MOUSE

So, you blame Red Cloak for the death of your relative. Is that why you invited him here to kill him? Why poison though? Why not challenge him to a duel? It's a fair fight then.

ASK: THE STALLION | THE SHARK | THE DRAGON

Maybe the letter refers to Red Cloak's threats to your family's reputation? Had he succeeded in seducing your sister? That would make you want him dead, and poison is a very subtle way to kill someone.

ASK: THE BLACK SWAN | THE SPARROW

That letter is a definite threat. Did you decide to kill him tonight because he refused to give your money back for the job he failed to complete?

ASK: THE LION

I can imagine you being quite angry at Red Cloak. Had he succeeded in seducing your daughter? That would make you want to kill him.

ASK: THE DOVE | THE UNICORN | THE BLUEBIRD

Poison can be quite a painful way to die. The kind of pain you might want to inflict on someone who hurt you. Maybe his letter was trying to manipulate you into forgiving him, but you'd already decided to make him suffer?

ASK: THE PHOENIX | THE HARE | THE FOX

That letter just screams blackmail. You were one of the few people who Red Cloak could blackmail. Is that why you decided to poison him?

ASK: THE DOG | THE TURTLE

Red Cloak had hurt and threatened people that you care about. Maybe you decided to get justice on him for the way he treated them?

ASK: THE WEASEL

Did you decide to poison Red Cloak to get rid of him because he threatened to expose your secret? As a man of God that would certainly be a moral dilemma for you.

ASK: THE WOLF | THE CAT

You don't have a lot of money yourselves, yet you gave quite a bit to Red Cloak. Maybe you decided to kill him when he refused to give it back when you needed it?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

*When another Player asks you a question,
read the appropriate answer.*

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

Red Cloak was dishonest, there's a reason he was cast out by The Countess. Unfortunately, he's the one you go to if you need a job doing discreetly. He has a reputation for dodgy dealings, I should never have approached him. I knew what I was getting myself into; I only have myself to blame for trusting a con man.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

Red Cloak was dishonest, there's a reason he was cast out by The Countess. Unfortunately, he's the one you go to if you need a job doing discreetly. He has a reputation for dodgy dealings, but desperation can make you do stupid things sometimes and when someone wrongs you, there are consequences. Guess he learnt that the hard way when someone killed him.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE STAG ROUND 4 OPPORTUNITY

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud. Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE SPARROW | THE BLACK SWAN | THE WOLF

You hired Red Cloak to do a job for you, he failed, and you asked for your money back, but he didn't give it to you. Were you trying to play nice to get him to trust you so you could kill him?

ASK: THE COUNTESS | THE MOUSE

It's clear that you were angry at Red Cloak; you blamed him for the death of your relative. It'd be quite easy for you to arrange to meet him somewhere to kill him. This is your house.

ASK: THE LION | THE DRAGON | THE STALLION | THE SHARK

Admit it; you wanted revenge on Red Cloak for trying to seduce your relative and nearly ruining your family's reputation. You care a lot about your position in society. Did you kill Red Cloak to protect your reputation?

ASK: THE HARE | THE PHOENIX | THE WEASEL | THE FOX

So Red Cloak found out things you didn't want anyone to know about. He was blackmailing you. It would make sense that you'd want to kill him for that. Did you trick him into meeting you here tonight?

ASK: THE TURTLE | THE DOG

You seek justice for the wrongs you feel have been done to the people you care about. Did you write that note to Red Cloak to draw him here to make him pay?

ASK: THE DOVE | THE UNICORN | THE BLUEBIRD

The note was written in an elegant hand. Female perhaps? They say "hell hath no fury like a woman scorned." Did you plan to poison Red Cloak tonight because he broke your heart?

ASK: THE CAT

A widow could hardly be a threat to him, so maybe Red Cloak thought he can get more money from you? Perhaps you saw his ulterior motive and wanted to trick him into coming here tonight so you could kill him?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

*When another Player asks you a question,
read the appropriate answer.*

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

He didn't fail at his job; he found the woman I was looking for. He found her quite quickly, she was in Venice, he didn't tell me that though. He kept pretending to still be looking for her so he could get more money out of me and, like a fool, I believed him. I didn't need to pretend to be nice though, I try to be polite and respectful towards everyone, even undeserving men like him. I've seen enough death in war, I wouldn't want to see anymore.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

He didn't fail at his job; he found the woman I was looking for. He found her quite quickly, she was in Venice, he didn't tell me that though. He kept pretending to still be looking for her so he could get more money out of me and like a fool I believed him. I didn't need to pretend to be nice though, I try to be polite and respectful towards everyone, even undeserving men like him. Keeping my love from me though is a step too far, he shouldn't have done that, and he paid for it.

**DO YOU KNOW WHODUNIT?
TURN THE PAGE TO SHARE YOUR DEDUCTIONS**

THE STAG

ACCUSATIONS OR VOTING

Follow the Host's instructions on how to name the Murderer.

- *You may fill out a Game Ballot on paper or via Chat.*
- *You may be asked to make an Accusation in the format below.*

Either way, the first Player to correctly identify the Murderer and motive wins the game. If nobody gets it right, the Murderer wins!

ACCUSATION FORMAT

I accuse _____ of murdering Red Cloak.

I believe their motive was:

OPTIONAL:

I base my accusation on this evidence:

THE STAG

FINAL STATEMENTS

When the Host calls on your assigned letter, share the appropriate Final Statement:

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

I didn't kill Red Cloak, I had no reason to. You see the woman I love, she's here, I found that out tonight. He tried to keep her from me, he even tried to blackmail her can you believe that? He thought, as did many others that her child was illegitimate but they're not. We were married in a legally binding ceremony and she conceived that night. I'll never forgive my father for sending her away and keeping me from my child; if he was still alive, I'd probably want to kill him, but Red Cloak, I can almost thank him really for reuniting me with my love and giving me a family; I had all but lost hope of ever finding them. I'm sorry he's dead, I should have liked to thank him.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

Yes I killed Red Cloak, he lied to me, he did the job and found the woman I love but he pretended he hadn't so he could keep taking my money, he even tried blackmailing her! I'm not going to allow that level of disrespect.

Red Cloak knew how important money and power is and he knew there would be consequences for going against me. It was made very clear to him when we agreed on the contract. He couldn't really expect me to just let it slide.

Arsenic is very easy to get hold of, it's found in everyday items. It's also invisible when added to liquid. The only clue might be an almond smell; however, The Countess' favourite food is sugared almonds and there was a whole plate full of them on the terrace and so anyone would assume the smell came from there.

Red Cloak would recognise my hand, I've practised very hard to make sure my writing looks elegant and reflects that of a respectable member of the gentry/even if I'm not part of it. And I knew Red Cloak would meet me as we still had so much unfinished business to discuss.

I made sure I'd spoken to the servants to bring two drinks of the finest wine out onto the terrace for me. While everyone was busy dancing in the main hall no one noticed me slip the powder into the goblet. It only takes a few seconds for it to disappear in the liquid and so when Red Cloak joined me, and I was apologetic and full of smiles, he suspected nothing and took the drink.

Once he'd taken the first sip, I knew it'd only take a few minutes until it kicked in and so I claimed I needed to use the privy, told him to enjoy the drink and I'd be back in a few minutes and slipped quietly back into the hall.

I was in here when he actually collapsed, and I feigned surprise with everyone else when the death was announced.

I'm not sorry he's dead, men like that deserve what happens to them, I just got there first.

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